

DARK SQUARES

Season Two – Episode One

"RAIN ON CONCRETE"

Written by Alfred HJR

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Timeline: The night of, and the first twenty-four hours after, Bloody Sweet 16.

Logline: As sirens approach Ella Mae's house, Manny must keep Keith from

fleeing while every friend realizes Bloody Sweet 16 has become a permanent dark square.

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PREVIOUSLY ON DARK SQUARES

*Brief montage: Keith's freestyle in the backyard. Lucky's final record. Chucky

confronting Keith in the rain. The fight. The slam. The silence. Uncle Candyman

calling 911. The crooked birthday banner. Manny looking at his brother. The

scratch of the needle on the record.*

TEASER

FADE IN:

EXT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE, ROCKS – NIGHT – CONTINUOUS

Rain needles the crooked birthday banner. **KEITH** kneels beside the unresponsive

CHUCKY**. ****SARAH**** presses her coat beneath Chucky's head. ****UNCLE CANDYMAN**

stands over both of them, phone to his ear, voice steady.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

Nobody runs. Nobody touches him. The truth is what it is. Keith's hands won't stop shaking.

KEITH

Chuck...

No answer.

KEITH

I didn't mean to. Manny. Manny, I didn't mean to.

MANNY pushes through the remaining guests to reach his brother. He drops to a

knee beside Chucky. He looks, assesses, cannot fix.

MANNY (V.O.)

There is a specific silence that comes after a thing that cannot be undone. The

rain was loud. The record was still scratching. But none of that was what I was

hearing.

Sirens in the distance. Getting closer.

MANNY (V.O.)

What I was hearing was everything that came before it, every choice, every

warning, every moment I thought I was keeping him safe.

CUT TO TITLE: DARK SQUARES

ACT ONE

INT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE – PRE-DAWN

Police and emergency responders move through the living room and into the yard.

The Sweet Sixteen is no longer a party. It is a scene.

The teenagers are separated. Notebooks and questions. The room that an hour ago held

music and food and Manny's birthday now holds blue light through the windows.

LUCKY moves quietly through the studio area. He removes the alcohol that Nate

brought. He removes his own protection – the gun kept to guard the equipment –

and takes it somewhere the responding officers will not find it. He does this

without panic. He has thought about this kind of night before.

MANNY stands at the window, watching the ambulance take Chucky away.

His birthday banner is still there. One corner has come untaped. It droops.

The paramedics are not running. They are moving with the deliberate pace of people

who know what they are doing and have decided that running does not help anymore.

MANNY (V.O.)

I watched them load Chucky up and I tried to remember everything I knew about him.

Tried to find some version of this night that made sense. Couldn't.

EXT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE – FRONT WALK – PRE-DAWN

BUTCH is moving guests toward the street, toward cabs, toward safe rides home.

He is calm. He is doing what needs doing. His phone buzzes – a name he recognizes,

someone who has heard already, someone who wants to know if there is neighborhood

business to conduct.

Butch declines the call. Pockets the phone.

NUTTY NATE and **CHEERIO** stand at the edge of the walk. Uncle Candyman finds

them and moves them out of the immediate scene. He tells them to go home, not

to talk to people they do not know tonight, and to call their parents.

Nate does not delete the Check Check thread. He holds the phone, thinks about it,

and does not delete it. He does not know yet what it means. He only knows it is accurate, and accuracy feels like the one thing worth preserving tonight.

INT. HOSPITAL WAITING AREA – MORNING

Fluorescent light. Chairs bolted to the floor. The specific nowhere of a hospital waiting room.

Chucky's mother sits at one end. She will not meet anyone's eyes. She has been told what she has been told and she has nothing left to offer the people who caused this.

A **DOCTOR** appears. Speaks low. The words travel.

DOCTOR

He is alive. He is critical. The next hours matter. Sarah closes her eyes.

SARAH

Alive is not the same as all right.

She is right. No one argues.

Manny and Keith sit side by side. Keith has not spoken in an hour. His hands are still in his lap. He keeps looking at them the way you look at something you do not recognize.

A **DETECTIVE** approaches. Identifies himself. Asks Keith to come with him for a statement.

INT. HOSPITAL – INTERVIEW ROOM – MORNING

Keith's statement, given in the flat language of shock:

KEITH

He swung first. I – we were outside. He swung and I grabbed him and I – I just

lifted him. I didn't think about where he was going to land.

The detective writes.

DETECTIVE

Have you ever been in a physical altercation before?

KEITH

No.

DETECTIVE

With Chucky?

KEITH

No. He's my friend.

(beat)

He was my friend.

The detective notes the tense. Says nothing about it.

DETECTIVE

The case remains open.

EXT. HOSPITAL — MORNING

Butch is outside when Sarah finds him.

BUTCH

Michelle get home?

SARAH

She's with her cousin.

(beat)

You good?

BUTCH

Doing what needs doing.

His phone buzzes. He looks at it. The same name.

SARAH

Who keeps calling?

BUTCH

Nobody important.

He declines it again.

BUTCH

People will write their own version of tonight if we let them.

MANNY (*stepping out*)

We don't get to write it.

Butch looks at him. Knows he's right.

ACT TWO

INT. ELLA MAE'S KITCHEN – DAY

Ella Mae came home in the dark. She stood in her living room – the room that the

rule was supposed to protect – and looked at what had replaced her party.

She did not cry then. She does not cry now.

She moves through the kitchen, making calls. Each call is the same: I'm sorry.

It happened here. My son. I know. I know.

Manny is on the front step, on his knees, scrubbing.

UNCLE CANDYMAN appears in the doorway.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

Leave that.

MANNY

No.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

Manny. It can wait.

MANNY

I'm not leaving it there.

Candyman watches him scrub for a moment.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

Being the older brother does not make you the father. You understand me?

Manny does not stop scrubbing.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

She is not blaming you.

MANNY

I know.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

Do you?

Manny stops. Looks up at him.

MANNY

I should have seen it coming.

UNCLE CANDYMAN

And if you had?

Manny does not answer. That is the answer.

Inside the kitchen, Ella Mae ends another call.

ELLA MAE

(to herself, to no one)

I gave them one rule.

INT. ELLA MAE'S KITCHEN — LATER

Ella Mae puts food in front of Keith. Keith stares at it.

ELLA MAE

Keith.

KEITH

I'm not hungry.

ELLA MAE

I did not ask.

(beat)

Eat.

He eats. Mechanically. She watches him.

ELLA MAE

You're going to tell me exactly what happened. Not tonight. When you're ready. And

you're going to tell me the truth, not what you think I want to hear.

KEITH

I know.

ELLA MAE

I'm not going to lose you to this.

KEITH

Mom —

ELLA MAE

I said I'm not going to lose you to this. Do you hear me? Keith looks at her. For a moment he is ten years old again and the only thing that matters is that she is in the room.

KEITH

I hear you.

INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY — FOLLOWING DAY

Sarah moves through the hall. People who were at the party look at her. People who heard about it look at her. She keeps her eyes forward.

CLASSMATE

How's Chucky?

SARAH

I don't know.

CLASSMATE

Someone said he's —

SARAH

I don't know.

She does not stop walking. She does not dress up what she witnessed. What she saw

was what she saw. The truth does not get softer because she whispers it.

Manny runs errands while Ella Mae's shifts continue. The house needs things.

Food. Certain bills. Butch appears at the door with grocery money from their shared small work.

Manny takes only enough to keep food in the house. Not more.

INT. LUCKY'S STUDIO – NIGHT

Lucky lets Keith in. He does not hand him a microphone. He gives him a task first. Moving equipment. Labeling a cassette stack that has been unlabeled for years. Practical work. The kind of work that makes a room into a room.

LUCKY

A beat can hold a feeling. It can't excuse one.

Keith accepts this without argument. He understands it is both permission and a boundary.

Later, Lucky hits record before Keith realizes it. Keith is talking – not

performing, talking. Lucky saves the rough take.

It is not a song. It is a person trying to understand himself out loud.

Lucky labels it. Sets it aside. Says nothing.

EXT. ROCKS CORNER – NIGHT

BOY GEORGE, an older neighborhood figure, finds Butch on the corner.

BOY GEORGE

I heard what happened at the party.

BUTCH

Most people did.

BOY GEORGE

The way you moved people out. Kept it from getting worse.

BUTCH

I did what needed doing.

BOY GEORGE

I got a situation that could use someone with steady hands.

BUTCH

I'm good.

BOY GEORGE

People are already asking who to talk to around here. That name is starting to

be yours.

Butch looks at him.

BUTCH

I didn't ask for it.

BOY GEORGE

Most people who have it didn't.

Manny watches from across the street. He sees the conversation. Sees the length

of it. Sees how Butch ends it and walks away.

He does not say anything yet. But he files it.

ACT THREE

INT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE – NIGHT

Ella Mae finds Manny in the kitchen at midnight.

ELLA MAE

You need to sleep.

MANNY

I know.

ELLA MAE

I need help, Manny. I'm not asking you to carry all of it. I need *help*.

He looks at her.

ELLA MAE

I don't need to lose you to helping.

He nods.

She puts her hand on his shoulder. The weight of it –
real, present, his mother –

is the most grounding thing that has happened to him in
two days.

ELLA MAE

We've had bad nights before.

MANNY

Not like this.

ELLA MAE

No. Not like this. But we are still here. And tomorrow we
are still going to be

here. You understand?

MANNY

Yes, ma'am.

INT. HOSPITAL – CHUCKY'S ROOM – DAY

Chucky's mother has agreed to one brief visit.

Keith stands at the door. He does not go all the way in.
Chucky is there, machine

sounds, the specific stillness of unconscious.

KEITH

(low, to himself)

Chuck. I'm sorry. Not because anyone told me to say it.
Because I mean it. I know

that doesn't change anything. I just need you to know.

He waits, as if expecting something. Nothing comes.

He steps back into the hall. He does not ask to be
forgiven.

Chucky's condition, memory, and future remain uncertain.
The case remains open.

EXT. GARAGE COURT – DAY

Butch on the court. A neighborhood basketball argument that has been simmering for three days is about to go somewhere it should not. Butch steps between the two kids. Calm.

BUTCH

We're not doing this.

KID #1

Tell him that.

BUTCH

I'm telling both of you. Walk it off. Come back tomorrow. Something in his voice – not threat, not performance – settles the air. The kids separate.

Nate, watching from the side of the court, notes who listened and how fast.

NATE

(to himself)

That's a problem.

EXT. ROCKS STREET – EARLY EVENING

A **DETECTIVE** finds Manny walking home.

DETECTIVE

Emmanuel.

Manny stops.

DETECTIVE

Chucky made it through the night. The investigation is still active.

MANNY

I know.

DETECTIVE

We're going to need your brother available. Means he's not leaving town. You understand?

MANNY

I'll tell him.

DETECTIVE

Make sure he understands what that means.

The detective walks away. Manny stands in the street for a moment.

He turns toward home.

ACT FOUR

INT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE – LATE NIGHT

Manny comes in to find Keith at the kitchen table. Keith's schoolwork is in front

of him. Beside it: a cassette. Beside that: an overdue bill that Ella Mae has circled twice.

Keith looks up.

KEITH

He's alive?

MANNY

Yeah. He made it through the night. They still don't know everything.

KEITH

Is he going to be okay?

MANNY

I don't know, Keith.

KEITH

Am I going to jail?

The question lands in the room like something dropped from a height.

Manny looks at his brother – ten years of looking at this face, knowing this face,
carrying this face – and tells him the truth.

MANNY

I don't know. We don't know yet. You can't leave town.
That's what they said.

KEITH

I didn't mean –

MANNY

I know.

KEITH

I keep saying that.

MANNY

I know you mean it.

Keith puts his face in his hands. He does not cry. He is
past crying for now. He

is somewhere further in.

Manny sits across from him.

MANNY

We take the next step.

KEITH

Even when it's heavy?

MANNY

Especially then.

INT. ELLA MAE'S HOUSE – LATER

Keith finally sleeps. Manny covers him where he has fallen
asleep at the table.

He does not move him. He covers him with the throw blanket
from the couch and

turns off the kitchen light.

He sits down in the dark.

Ella Mae's voice from the hallway.

ELLA MAE

Manny.

MANNY

Yeah.

ELLA MAE

Sleep.

He does not argue. He knows she is right. He knows that what is coming is going

to require him rested, present, and able to think.

He folds his arms on the table and closes his eyes where he sits.

The house breathes around him.

TAG

EXT. ROCKS BLOCK – DAWN

The neighborhood wakes around Ella Mae's house. Regular sounds. Cars starting.

Birds. The city going about its business without asking permission.

Manny comes out to the porch. The birthday banner is still hanging. He does not

take it down yet. He looks at it.

He looks at the front step he scrubbed.

He looks at the street, which is just a street again.

He locks the front door behind him, checks that it is locked, and looks at the

repaired porch light.

MANNY (V.O.)

No one is rescued by morning. They are only given another choice.

He can hear the city moving beyond the block. One sound underneath all of it:

the scratch of the record. Lucky's last song, still running in his head.

He breathes. He takes the next step.

MANNY (V.O.)

Bloody Sweet 16 was the name the neighborhood was going to give it.

(beat)

We would spend a long time learning what the name meant.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

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